

# Toddler Meal Time Snack Negotiations — Action Checklist

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## UNDERSTAND WHY SNACKS WIN

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- ☐ **Identify that snack foods are engineered with salt, fat, and sugar to override natural hunger signals, which means you're not losing a willpower battle but fighting against carefully designed food science that was built to win.:** Identify that snack foods are engineered with salt, fat, and sugar to override natural hunger signals, which means you're not losing a willpower battle but fighting against carefully designed food science that was built to win.
- ☐ **Recognize that your toddler's inconsistent eating patterns throughout the day are normal developmental behavior, not a behavioral problem that requires punishment or pressure to correct.:** Recognize that your toddler's inconsistent eating patterns throughout the day are normal developmental behavior, not a behavioral problem that requires punishment or pressure to correct.
- ☐ **Stop trying to willpower your way through dinner negotiations with more resolve, because the real problem is a system design issue that requires restructuring rather than more parental effort.:** Stop trying to willpower your way through dinner negotiations with more resolve, because the real problem is a system design issue that requires restructuring rather than more parental effort.
- ☐ **Understand that your fear of the 7:45pm hangry meltdown is what keeps the cycle running, because your toddler has learned that waiting long enough produces desperation and snacks.:** Understand that your fear of the 7:45pm hangry meltdown is what keeps the cycle running, because your toddler has learned that waiting long enough produces desperation and snacks.

## SET UP THE ANYTIME SHELF

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- ☐ **Choose a low shelf or accessible drawer where your toddler can independently reach food without asking permission, which removes you from the role of constant snack gatekeeper.:** Choose a low shelf or accessible drawer where your toddler can independently reach food without asking permission, which removes you from the role of constant snack gatekeeper.
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- **Stock your Anytime Shelf with reliable, functional options like whole fruit, cheese cubes, crackers, and hard-boiled eggs that satisfy hunger without creating excitement around food access.:** Stock your Anytime Shelf with reliable, functional options like whole fruit, cheese cubes, crackers, and hard-boiled eggs that satisfy hunger without creating excitement around food access.

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- **Restock your Anytime Shelf with fresh options every single day so your toddler develops genuine trust that food will always be there, which eliminates the panic-driven bargaining behavior.:** Restock your Anytime Shelf with fresh options every single day so your toddler develops genuine trust that food will always be there, which eliminates the panic-driven bargaining behavior.

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- **Keep treats and dessert items completely off the Anytime Shelf, reserving them for the Sometimes Foods category, because that shelf is meant for hunger management not reward systems.:** Keep treats and dessert items completely off the Anytime Shelf, reserving them for the Sometimes Foods category, because that shelf is meant for hunger management not reward systems.

## PROTECT THE STRUCTURE

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- **Never withhold all snacks to force your toddler to eat dinner, because this creates scarcity mindset and often makes the refusing-to-eat problem significantly worse over time.:** Never withhold all snacks to force your toddler to eat dinner, because this creates scarcity mindset and often makes the refusing-to-eat problem significantly worse over time.

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  - **Never use the Anytime Shelf foods as rewards for finishing dinner, because this immediately corrupts the structure by teaching your toddler that snacks have conditional value.:** Never use the Anytime Shelf foods as rewards for finishing dinner, because this immediately corrupts the structure by teaching your toddler that snacks have conditional value.

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  - **Move all sometimes foods like crackers and fruit pouches to high cabinets or the pantry so your toddler learns these require a request rather than being always available.:** Move all sometimes foods like crackers and fruit pouches to high cabinets or the pantry so your toddler learns these require a request rather than being always available.

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  - **Accept that your toddler will sometimes skip meals entirely and trust their internal hunger regulation, because forcing intake undermines the system you've built.:** Accept that your toddler will sometimes skip meals entirely and trust their internal hunger regulation, because forcing intake undermines the system you've built.
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